mance resulted. Recently, Gujarat requested the Centre to postpone the Par-Tapi-Narmada interlinking project—a promise Patil had made to protesters in May. And CM Bhupendra Patel scrapped the Gujarat Cattle Control in Urban Areas Bill, which envisaged a fine for stray cattle on city streets, after Patil assured the cattle-rearing Maldhari community it would be. 'Assertive Patil' and 'humble Patel'...partymen see it as a virtuous contrast.

Besides his demonstrated skills, his proximity to PM Modi is a big factor behind his clout. His mentor since the beginning of Patil's political career in 1989, Modi made him president of the Gujarat Industrial Development Corporation after becoming CM in 2002. He was Modi's poll coordinator in 2019 when the PM contested the Varanasi Lok Sabha seat. This March, when the PM held a roadshow in Ahmedabad, Patil accompanied him and CM Patel. Patil's popularity in his Lok Sabha constituency Navsari is indicated by his huge victory margins of 560,000 and 689,000 votes, respectively, in the 2014 and 2019 elections.

Patil has seen many ups and downs in his journey to where he is today. In 1984, as a constable, he was suspended for trying to form a union within the Gujarat Police. In 2002, he was arrested for defaulting on payments amounting to Rs 54 crore to Diamond Jubilee Cooperation Bank. He eventually returned Rs 84 crore, including interest, and didn't let the muck stick. In April, Delhi CM Arvind Kejriwal questioned his loyalty towards Gujarat by pointing to his Maharashtra roots—Patil was born in Jalgaon in 1955, before his family shifted to Surat. "It was Bombay Presidency then. Maharashtra and Gujarat took shape only in 1960," says one of Patil's supporters. His next job will be to choose candidates who beat off anti-incumbency and new challengers from 'outside'. ■



BENGALURU

# Bangalored? Take a Train

By Ajay Sukumaran

Anyone in Bengaluru knows the two conversation-starters—the weather and the traffic. The first has held up impeccably through a heatwave that scorched much of the country. The latter hasn't disappointed either—Bengaluru's notorious traffic is getting back to its pre-pandemic levels.

Back in 2019, Bengaluru ranked as the most congested city globally in the Amsterdam-based TomTom Traffic Index. It fell to the tenth position in 2021, thanks to the pandemic, while Mumbai overtook it to reach No. 5 and Delhi was at No. 11. However, there was a difference: Mumbai has a dependable local rail network that ferried nearly eight million commuters every day in 2019 while six million rode the Delhi Metro daily that year. In contrast, Bengaluru's 6,500-odd city buses and its 56-km metroline put together transported about four million.

Public transport infrastructure has been Bengaluru's bane. Bengaluru was the first Indian city in India to launch low-floor Volvo buses in 2006, but overall bus ridership has declined in the past decade—from five million daily passengers in 2014-15 to three million in 2019-20. Meanwhile, the city currently has over 10 million registered vehicles.

Or take, for instance, the idea of a suburban rail system that was first mooted in the early '80s. On June 20, Prime Minister Narendra Modi laid the foundation stone for such a network, promising that the suburban rail, pending for 40 years, would be completed in 40 months. The Rs 15,700-crore Bengaluru Suburban Rail Project (BSRP) will connect the city's industrial hubs to ferry an estimated one million passengers.

The BSRP will build on an existing network of railway tracks and stations on which a few commuter trains plied. Yet it took public campaigns over several years to prod the project forward. In fact, these commuter trains had built up a loyal